

Master Plan Implementation Committee (MPIC) Solar Subcommittee Meeting Minutes Thursday, September 5, 2024

Committee Members Present: Teri Anderson, Susan Bronstein, Jen Milikowsky, Doug Finn (via Zoom)

School Department Present: Vito Perrone, School Superintendent

Call to Order 5:30pm

School Solar Projects: Reviewed solar conceptual plan done to date for elementary school ground mounted system.

Superintendent Perrone noted that the elementary school roof is in the capital improvement plan but 5 years out. Solar panels on roof are not possible until it is replaced. Yes, the school is open to parking lot canopy solar systems similar to those at River Valley Market in Easthampton. They prefer not to lose green space.

As for the roof at the high school, there are problems with HVAC systems on the roof. Would prefer solar canopies on parking lot there as well.

The high school electric rate was recently renegotiated with EverSource-saved a lot but costs remain high. Need to analyze payback period. A high school project would need approval from other towns on the regional school committee. Best to keep as a separate project. The regional school district is eligible to apply for grants on its own.

Need to confirm that regional school districts are exempt from the Eversource solar caps similar to municipalities. Jen will email MA DOE staff to confirm.

Discussed whether 3 phase electric upgrade to landfill should be included in an application. Will consider its eligibility and whether the grant will be sufficient to cover those costs.

Agreed on the following:

- Agreed prioritize the elementary school project in part because the town would like to use the site as an emergency shelter in the future.
- Prefer to include replacing the generator with battery backup system. Need to confirm battery systems are an eligible expense and also exempt from Eversource caps.
- We need to ask Solect to prepare another assessment for parking lot canopies to estimate cost and confirm feasibility in advance of applying for

design/construction funding. Analyze both lots at the elementary school. See if they will evaluate at no cost or evaluate if we have sufficient ARPA funds remaining to cover the cost. Also the elementary school has some SR3 funds left this year that could be potentially be used if needed.

- Agreed that we should apply for a Municipal Vulnerability Grant for the elementary school under the upcoming round this winter for the FY26 grant year.
- Agreed to separate the high school project and apply for Green Schools grant for that project since it is likely eligible as a Title 1 school under current grant guidelines and the State is encouraging school renewable energy projects. It is too late to apply for this year. Will need to keep an eye out on the schedule for the next funding round.
- Will need to talk with MVP regional coordinator about potential application.

Next Steps for School Solar Projects:

- Superintendent Perrone will discuss the elementary and high school projects with the respective School Committee chairs.
- Doug Finn will call Solect to get more information on a parking lot canopy assessment and preliminary costs estimates for elementary school.
- Doug Finn and Teri Anderson will arrange a phone call with Emma Sass, MVP Coordinator to discuss a potential application. Teri will prepare some questions. If it looks feasible, Doug will file an Expression of Interest to apply by the November 1 deadline. (Note: an EOI is not required to apply but appreciated)

Town Hall and Public Safety Building Solar Projects Update:

- 21 companies requested the RFP. Site walk is set for 9/6/24.
- Doug will begin preparing the draft FRP for the Public Safety Building project using the town hall RFP as a baseline. He would like to see spring construction start and connection by year's end 2025.

Other Business:

Motion to Approve the Minutes of 8/6/24: Moved by Susan Bronstein; seconded by Jennifer Milikowsky, voted unanimously.

Doug proposes Town Hall parking lot electric charger stations. Discussed charges with solar panels is preferred. Committee supports the concept provided the town can obtain a grant to cover the costs.

Next meeting: No formal Solar Subcommittee meetings scheduled at this time. Doug will ask solar committee members to be on the town hall solar proposal evaluation team

which will meet on Thursday, October 24, 2024 at 5:30 pm exclusively to review and rate town hall solar proposals. Meeting will be hybrid and in person at town hall.

Motion to Adjourn at 6:32pm by Scott, seconded by Sue, voted unanimously.

Submitted By,
Teri Anderson